

Disabilities Sensitivity Training and Anti-Bullying Workshop

History

The Friendship Circle, founded in 1994 in Detroit, Michigan, extends a helping hand to families who have children and teenagers with special needs, ranging from muscular dystrophy to autism, and involves them in a full range of social, recreational and respite opportunities.

The Friendship Circle also fills a vital need for meaningful volunteer opportunities for teenagers who, with the support of professional social workers, provide the respite and friendship to the families and children. All teen volunteers participate in intensive training, including onsite guidance and seminars given by professionals in the field.

Through this unique formula of shared experiences, all are enriched:

- The child/teen with special needs looks forward to the opportunity to play with and learn from their friends and appreciates the companionship of peers which is often times lacking in their lives.
- The teenage volunteer learns the value of giving, and cherishes the experience of making a difference in a child's life and bringing a smile to his or her face.
- The child's family receives a needed respite and the pleasure of seeing their child become a part of the community.

The Friendship Circle programs include home respite visits, music, sports and art therapy programs, summer and winter camps, and much more.

The Detroit model has since been replicated in 42 cities across the United States, with many others looking to start the program in the near future. Currently, more than 3,000 families who have children with special needs benefit from our programs. The teen volunteer club boasts 5,500 members nationwide and is growing. The impact of the Friendship Circle is multiplied by the friendships and support system that grows between the families of the volunteers and the special needs families. Thus by extension the Circle actually includes tens of thousands of people.

Each independent Friendship Circle is operated by its local center, and all operations and programs are supported entirely by the local community of each Friendship Circle. However, all the centers work closely together to share resources, materials and ideas. The New Jersey, Pennsylvania and Michigan offices are coordinating this initiative.

Proposed Workshop

Our experience has given us a keen understanding of the positive impact that individuals and the community at large can have on people with disabilities and their families and the impact that these children and families have on the teen volunteers. We are looking to expand this effect through a multi-media interactive workshop to be presented at middle and high schools across the country.

The workshop will focus on creating a general awareness about persons with physical and mental disabilities, highlighting their similarities to the teenagers in the audience as well as their differences. The goal of the program is to break down barriers between people with disabilities and those in the community unaware of how to approach and befriend each other while stressing the beneficial impact of a positive attitude.

Notes from Friendship Circle Conference Call May 18, 2004

On the call were Rabbi Zalman Grossbaum, Rabbi Yudi Shemtov, Judith Orloff and Sarah Cardet

Judith opened by talking about a contact of hers that could be a possible resource for this project who works with people with disabilities. His website is www.mtc-inc.com.

Discussion points:

Zalman

- This is broader than just a recruitment tool.
- He wants to get clear before signing a contract so we don't get down the road and discover we are not aligned.
- He wants this to be sensitivity training and have recruitment be an end result.
- He discovered major philosophical issues on the Normemma website that struck him as very powerful
- He wants Norm and Emma on board on the project to help with content but not with how the material is presented. Then at the end of the development he wants them to see and approve the program
- Not only does he want their endorsement but he wants their ideas

General

- We want to create a paradigm shift regarding people with disabilities.
- Disabled people are essentially the same as everyone else with an added gift/challenge and lesson to offer others
- We see the sensitivity training as valuable in schools not just to sensitize the students to seeing disabled people as equals but also to help reduce the incidence of bullying
- Judith spoke about her understanding of Norm's point of view and how valuable it is and we discussed arranging a conference call soon
- We envision a 30 minute "teaser" to introduce the program to decision-makers
- We spoke of the current concept being true to the Rebbe's vision
- Judith and Sarah will create another contract for consideration incorporating the ideas from this conference call and some of the language from Zalman's grant proposal and send to Zalman and Yudi by some time this week.
- Judith stated that the development cost will most likely be different for the new concept

Sensitizing teenagers to the challenges that people with disabilities face and making them aware of the commonalities that unite us all is the first step towards providing an overall respect for each person's differences, be they physical, racial, socioeconomic or otherwise, and providing teenagers with the skills necessary for looking beyond differences to find the similarities that friendships can be built on. With sensitivity and the ability to reach out to others, teenagers are much less likely to bully their peers as this behavior is most often the outgrowth of a lack of sensitivity and a sense that differences are inherently bad and often times insurmountable. Instead teenagers are encouraged to find common ground with each other and form friendships.

The positive effect of disability sensitivity training on teenagers and the resulting decrease in bullying behavior has been evidenced so far in our research. We have found that teens who volunteer with the Friendship Circle and other similar programs have also become more respectful and understanding towards peers who are labeled as "outcasts" because of their differences. In addition, these volunteers are much less likely to engage in bullying activities when compared to the overall communal and school population.

The proposed one-day workshop will include discussions, improvisational exercises and videos directed by a trained facilitator to help involve the teens in the learning process. Each participant will be asked to assume scenarios and navigate challenges that are routinely experienced by people with disabilities and to engage in discussions and develop ideas for surpassing these situations. The facilitator will then engage the teenagers to translate the lessons learned from these experiences to the differences and challenges faced by those within the teens' peer groups and community. Communication skills will be emphasized, modeled and rewarded.

Plan of Action

We have enlisted the help of Orloff Consulting of Boulder, Colorado to create the workshop. We are in the process of involving nationally recognized authorities who specialize in disability awareness to assist with the creative process.

We are looking to run this workshop as a pilot program through the Friendship Circles in California, Michigan, New Jersey and Pennsylvania. During the first four months, we will run 30 workshops at various public and private middle and high schools. We will work with participating educators and teens to perfect the program and to maximize its effectiveness.

Once the presentation is fine-tuned, we will launch the program nationally. We anticipate reaching 15,000 teenagers during the first year and doubling that amount in the first three years.

Funding

We are looking for seed money for the creative process and for the pilot program. Each independent Friendship Circle will find local grants and other sources of funding to implement the program in their city.

Contact

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